

Too tired to cook, so you order in instead

8 findings · 15-step checklist · 1 myth · 7 sources · cheatgrid.com

Tonight's tiredness makes cooking feel heavier than it will turn out to be. A meal you make yourself is usually **worth more to you afterward**, partly because you made it.

THE GOAL

You're deciding by what you'll be glad of at the end of the evening. Open the fridge for real and name two things you could actually cook.

CHECKLIST

It's evening, you're wiped, standing at the fridge with your keys still in your pocket, and your phone is already open to a delivery app.

- ☐ Put your keys and bag down properly before you decide anything, so your hands are free.
- ☐ Open the fridge and cupboard for real, and name two or three things you could cook with what's there.
- ☐ Say out loud which way you're leaning, cooking or ordering, before you touch the delivery app.
- ☐ If you're cooking, pick whichever option is **simplest to make** right now, not the version you'd cook with more energy.
- ☐ If you're cooking, start on it within five minutes, before the tiredness talks you out of it.
- ☐ If you're cooking, check in halfway: keep going if it's manageable, or simplify further if it isn't.
- ☐ If you're ordering, picture the coffee, the gas, or whatever else this money would go toward instead.
- ☐ If you're ordering, close the app once you've decided, instead of still comparing other options.
- ☐ If you're ordering, **move instead of just scrolling** while you wait, with your hands or your body.
- ☐ Put the meal on a plate, whether you cooked it or it arrived in a box.
- ☐ Eat the meal without also scrolling, at least for the first few minutes.
- ☐ Write down, on your phone or a note, what made tonight feel this tiring.
- ☐ Before bed, set out one thing that makes tomorrow's dinner easier, like a washed vegetable or a defrosted portion.
- ☐ If this is happening most nights this week, **treat it as a sign to change** your kitchen routine, not proof you can't manage.
- ☐ Once you've eaten, set a stop time for the evening, so tonight still has a proper end.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Feeling like you messed something up today doesn't make you want to avoid effort. People made to feel less capable were the ones **most likely** to choose the hands-on, build-it-yourself option.
- 2** The dinner you're dreading will likely be worth more to you after it's made, because **you made it yourself**.
- 3** People who built a small thing themselves reported feeling more upbeat right after than people who examined an identical, ready-made version.

The story you're telling yourself

KNOW

Feeling like you messed something up today doesn't make you want to avoid effort. People made to feel less capable were the ones **most likely** to choose the hands-on, build-it-yourself option.

People given very hard math problems later **preferred to assemble their own furniture** than people given easy problems did. [Source 1](#)

DO

Cook the plainest version you can tonight, and finish it. Feeling like a real cook is not required.

Whether someone rated themselves a do-it-yourself fan or not made no difference to the size of the boost from finishing it. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

People who pay occasionally to skip a task they don't want to do report **higher life satisfaction**, across several countries surveyed.

In a two-week experiment, working adults reported better mood after a time-saving purchase than after spending the same amount on a material one. [Source 3](#)

The payoff you're underrating

KNOW

The dinner you're dreading will likely be worth more to you after it's made, because **you made it yourself**.

People who assembled a storage box themselves paid nearly two-thirds more for it than people given an identical, ready-made box. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Sitting down and doing nothing rarely delivers the good, fully absorbed feeling you're hoping for. Working adults tracked for a week reported that feeling far more during work than during leisure.

Flow needs a task that stretches your skill without overwhelming it, which ordinary cooking can meet more easily than passive scrolling. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

People who built a small thing themselves reported feeling more upbeat right after than people who examined an identical, ready-made version.

Feeling more capable after finishing something built by hand was directly linked to feeling more positive afterward. [Source 1](#)

The blind spots in tonight's math

WATCH

Opening the app without naming what this money could buy instead isn't a decision, it's a **skip**.

People shown cues to weigh alternatives picked the pricier option less often, even when they were already pushed to think it through. [Source 5](#)

DO

Change something in tonight's kitchen setup for tomorrow, before you rely on intentions. Old cues beat new intentions, most times.

Even when moving changed students' intentions, that shift alone did not explain why old TV, exercise or reading habits broke down. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

By evening you've used up a limited stash of willpower, so caving and ordering in isn't really a choice, it's just what happens once that stash runs out.

ACTUALLY

A large, multi-lab attempt to reproduce this exact effect found it was **close to zero**. Whatever makes cooking feel harder by evening, a measurable stash of willpower running out isn't it. [Source 7](#)

Sources

1. <https://dash.harvard.edu/server/api/core/bitstreams/7312037c-fb4e-6bd4-e053-0100007fdf3b/content>
2. <https://dash.harvard.edu/server/api/core/bitstreams/7312037d-2473-6bd4-e053-0100007fdf3b/content>
3. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC5559044/>
4. <https://onwork.edu.au/bibitem/1989-Csikszentmihalyi,M-LeFevre,J-Optimal+experience+in+work+and+leisure/>
5. <https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:oup:jconrs:v:36:y:2009:i:4:p:553-561>
6. https://dornsife.usc.edu/wendy-wood/wp-content/uploads/sites/183/2023/10/Wood.Tam_GuerreroWitt.2005_Changing_circumstances_disrupting_habits.pdf
7. <https://www.diva-portal.org/smash/get/diva2:1293233/FULLTEXT01.pdf>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Cooking at home more often at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)